

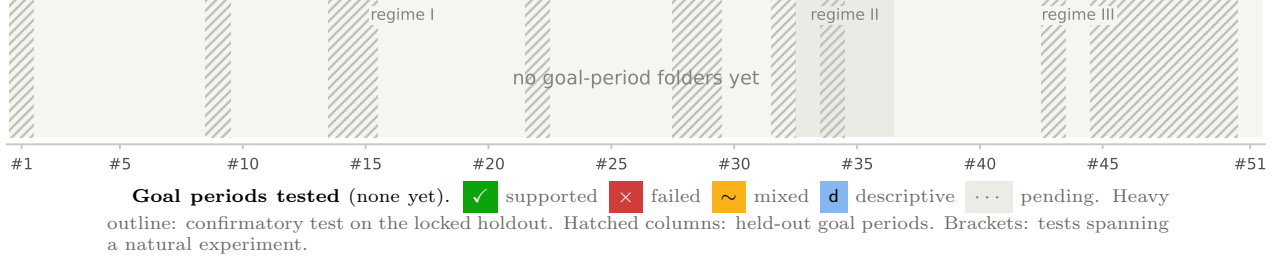
H09: Agent swarms have an effective thermodynamics

Vivian Rogers, with Claude Opus 5.5 · agent-swarm physics · Updated 2026-10-04

Complete 25% Faithfulness 1.5/5 Usefulness 2/5

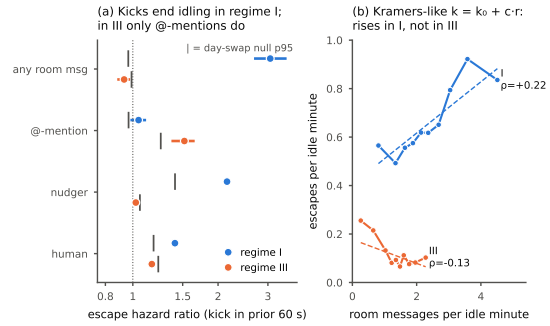
Bottom line. As a framing, swarm thermodynamics has not yet earned its keep; its best result is a practical fact about scheduling: in the current scaffold, idle agents are timer-gated, and only @-mentions get through.

level: hypothesis · pipeline checks 14% · updated 2026-10-04



WHAT HAPPENED

An exploratory framing, not one test: can swarm statistics be read as thermodynamics (landscapes, currents, traps, equations of state)? Two light non-holdout rounds; no score-card or holdout run. Round 1: the activity landscape's two wells are reproduced by the daily schedule (a field, not coupling). Per-agent action chains are irreversible (78% of cells beat the null), with a closed regime-III cycle consolidate → search → talk → pause, but event-level entropy production collapses after perma-computer-use. Agents are ergodic at day scale; restarts relax within a minute. Round 2 built reusable tables (`idle_runs`, `consolidation_inflow`). In regime I, room messages trigger escape from idling (hazard ratio 3.06; null p95 0.96). In regime III a pause is a self-set timer (0.22% end early), and only @-mentions matter ($\times 1.52$), at expiry. Memory size is an agent-specific set point, reset at each consolidation and barely moved by inflow. Collective entropy production: small (plug-in only).



Observables. (a) Escape hazard ratio of idle spells: minutes with a kick in the previous 60 s vs. minutes without, stratified by elapsed dwell and time of day. Bars: agent-day bootstrap CIs where computed; ticks: 95th percentile of a day-swap null. Regime I: any room message triples escape. Regime III: room messages don't help; only @-mentions do. (b) Escape rate against kick rate over agent-day deciles (dashed: linear fit $k_0 + cr$). It rises in I and falls in III.

SO WHAT? PRACTICAL VALUE FOR UNDERSTANDING AGENT SWARMS

The thermodynamic vocabulary did little work; the useful findings are plain mechanics. The one an operator can use: in the current scaffold (regime III), an idle agent is asleep on a timer it set itself. Room chatter does not wake it. Only an @-mention raises the chance it acts, and only when the timer expires. To get a response, address the agent by name and expect a delay of up to its chosen pause. Regime-I agents were interruptible. "Memory size is a set point" says consolidation is a reset, not growing storage. The rest restates the scaffold: landscapes made by the schedule, day-scale ergodicity, and a consolidation cycle that is the prompt's own loop. Nothing here yet beats a simpler statistic.

$$\begin{aligned} \lambda(t) &= P(\text{escape at } t \mid \text{idle until } t), & \text{HR} &= \lambda_{\text{kick}} / \lambda_{\text{none}} \\ \text{regime I (Kramers-like):} & k \approx k_0 + cr \\ \text{regime III (timer gate):} & \lambda(t) \approx \delta(t - t^*) p_{\text{gate}}(\text{@-mention}) \\ \sigma &= \sum_{x < y} (\pi_x P_{xy} - \pi_y P_{yx}) \ln \frac{\pi_x P_{xy}}{\pi_y P_{yx}} \\ \Delta V &= \beta P_{\text{in}} - \gamma V_{\text{prev}} \Rightarrow V^* = \beta P_{\text{in}} / \gamma \end{aligned}$$

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RESULTS VS PREDICTIONS

Pending.

GOAL PERIODS IN DETAIL

No goal-period folders yet.

FAITHFULNESS SCORECARD

A mapping	–	F identifiability	–
B assumptions	–	G ground truth	–
C adequacy	–	H comparative	–
D unfitted predictions	–	I transfer	–
E interventional	–		

Level: **hypothesis**. Scale 0 not done or failed, 1 partial, 2

passed (writeup/paper.tex).

CAVEATS

Pending.

ROUND 2

- **Essence.** Tokens are the energy, progress is the work, and context resets are the heat.
- **H09-R1** Token thermodynamics: power = tokens per hour; efficiency = progress (work ledger) per token; loops waste tokens at zero efficiency.
- **H09-R2** Consolidation is Landauer-like erasure: tokens spent consolidating vs information kept.
- **H09-R3** The swarm is a driven-dissipative steady state whose throughput is limited by attention, not compute (E5).

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